

CHAPTER 16 — The Contract

By six thirty, everyone who worked for Mac had gone home.

The receptionist had covered her monitor with a dust cloth. The accounts office was dark. Somewhere at the far end of the corridor, a cleaner moved a vacuum slowly between desks beneath framed certificates declaring standards nobody in the building had ever been asked to define.

Mac remained in his office.

The room was designed to leave no useful memory. Pale walls. Grey carpet. Two visitor chairs positioned at identical angles. A desk large enough to suggest authority without suggesting vanity. The window overlooked a car park, a fenced service yard and the backs of three other buildings equally determined not to be noticed.

Mac liked rooms that did not testify.

On his desk, beside an aligned row of pens, a tablet displayed the location of Elias's hatchback.

The dot had passed the grandmother's exit long enough ago that traffic could no longer explain it.

It had continued beyond the next junction, stopped briefly at a roadside rest area, moved again, left the motorway and entered a network of secondary roads that made no sense as a mistake.

Mac had called four times.

The first two calls had rung out.

The third had been rejected.

The fourth had been followed by the phone going dead.

He looked again at the tracker display.

The dot moved.

Slowly now.

Deliberately.

Mac placed the tablet flat on the desk and adjusted the nearest pen by less than the width of a fingernail.

Elias had not panicked.

That was the problem.

Panic wandered. It doubled back, missed junctions, stopped too long, switched phones badly and spent money in places where cameras could see it.

The route on Mac's screen showed none of those things.

It showed a man who had made a decision.

The tracker had not been part of the airport collection instructions.

It had been fitted beneath the hatchback's rear quarter two days earlier, while Elias believed a loose heat shield was being repaired in Mac's service yard.

Mac placed trackers on vehicles used for sensitive work as a matter of policy. Drivers were told when disclosure was useful and not told when it was not.

The device had not been installed because Mac expected Elias to defect.

That would have required admitting he believed Elias capable of it.

Mac had never believed the gaps in Elias's history were innocent. He had simply found it more profitable not to ask what they concealed.

Elias arrived when called. He completed what he accepted. He did not steal. He did not drink on the job. He did not ask who owned the addresses at either end of a journey.

That arrangement had suited both men.

Mac opened Elias's personnel file on the desktop computer.

The file was thin.

Proof of address. Licence. Insurance. Tax records. Employment references obtained from people who no longer answered the numbers listed beside their names. A history of short jobs separated by longer

periods described only as self-employment.

No military record.

No criminal convictions.

No family contact.

No social-media history worth preserving.

The file had always been too clean.

Mac had noticed.

He had also noticed that asking the wrong question could turn a useful man into a complicated one.

So he had not asked.

The cleaner's vacuum stopped outside the office.

A knock followed.

Mac closed the file.

"Come in."

The cleaner opened the door by a few inches. She was in her sixties, wore blue gloves and had worked in the building for seven years without ever asking what Mac's business actually did.

"Are you staying late?"

"For a while."

"I'll leave this end."

"Thank you."

She glanced at the tablet, saw only a map and a moving dot, and closed the door.

The vacuum began again farther down the corridor.

Mac waited until the sound had faded.

Then his private phone rang.

Cain.

Mac watched it ring twice before answering.

"Your driver has disappeared," Cain said.

There was no greeting. Cain rarely spent words on transitions.

"He has deviated from the route."

"That is a careful way to describe it."

"I know where the vehicle is."

"For now."

Mac looked at the tracker.

The dot had entered another village and was passing through without stopping.

"What do you want?"

"To know whether you understand what you sent to collect her."

Mac leaned back in his chair.

"I sent a driver."

Cain gave a quiet sound that might have been amusement.

"One of my men saw him earlier today at the service station."

Mac's eyes returned to the screen.

"Which man?"

"My lieutenant."

"The one who failed to recover the girl?"

"The one who had four men with him and decided not to follow your driver into a confined space."

Mac said nothing.

Cain continued.

"He recognised him."

"From where?"

"He would not say."

"Then he did not recognise him."

"He went pale."

Mac's right thumb pressed once against the squared edge of the desk.

Cain noticed silence the way other men noticed shouting.

"That interests you," he said.

"It tells me your lieutenant frightens easily."

"No. It tells you he has a memory."

The vacuum stopped again somewhere beyond the wall.

Mac could hear the building settling around him: ventilation, pipes, a door closing on another floor.

"What name did he give you?" Mac asked.

"No name."

"Then this conversation is useless."

"One word."

Cain paused.

Mac knew exactly the kind of word.

He had spent years refusing to ask whether one particular word belonged to Elias.

"I will not repeat it on an unsecured line," Cain said. "You know the kind of word I mean."

"I do not deal in legends."

"You deal in whatever keeps you alive."

Mac looked at Elias's file on the monitor.

Ordinary licences.

Ordinary references.

A life made of documents whose principal achievement was existing.

Cain lowered his voice.

"If the story is true, you did not lose control of an employee. You placed the girl in the passenger seat of a man who used to remove organisations more competent than yours."

The insult was deliberate.

Mac ignored it.

"Why did your lieutenant allow them to leave?"

"He says he was assessing."

"He was afraid."

"Yes."

Cain admitted it without embarrassment.

That disturbed Mac more than denial would have.

"My people will handle the girl," Cain said. "You should handle the man."

"She is not yours to handle."

"Your paperwork says otherwise?"

Mac's thumb pressed harder against the desk edge.

The answer was buried beneath enough transfers, placements and custodial authorities to survive casual inspection. Cain knew that. Cain had helped build some of them.

But the flight had been Mac's channel.

The collector had been Mac's.

The grandmother address had been Mac's.

Cain had not been invited into that part of the route.

"You failed to contain her," Mac said. "Your involvement is finished."

Cain was silent for a moment.

Then he laughed once.

"You still think there are parts of this that belong to you."

The line went dead.

Mac remained where he was until the phone screen dimmed.

He woke it with one touch.

The tracker dot continued into the dark.

The mistake had not been failing to investigate Elias.

It had been deciding that whatever he discovered would be less useful than the man who kept turning up, doing the work and asking no questions.

Mac opened a locked drawer and removed a second phone.

The contact list contained nine names.

Six were dead, retired or no longer trusted.

Three remained useful.

He called Voss first.

Voss listened without interrupting.

"Location?" he asked when Mac finished.

"Live vehicle tracker. Access on acceptance."

"Head start?"

"Several hours."

"Target profile?"

"Male. Mid-forties. Driver. No confirmed weapons."

A pause.

"Confirmed," Voss repeated.

"No declared weapons."

"Better."

"Travelling with a thirteen-year-old girl. She is to be recovered alive and physically unharmed."

"Relationship?"

"Employee interference in a protected placement."

Another pause.

"Who else is on the job?"

"Reyes and Vale."

"That is more team than a driver requires."

"He may have assistance."

"You said he was alone."

"I said he was travelling alone."

Voss let the distinction remain where Mac had placed it.

"Send the documents."

The call ended.

Reyes answered on the first ring.

"How difficult?"

"Potentially."

"How many?"

"One man."

"Then not very."

"There is a girl with him."

"Collateral?"

"Principal recovery. No damage."

"And him?"

"Discretionary."

Reyes laughed softly.

Mac had heard that laugh before jobs that ended with broken furniture and before jobs that ended with funerals. The sound meant the same thing in both cases: Reyes had found a reason to enjoy himself.

"Fee?"

Mac named it.

The laughter stopped.

"For a driver?"

"For speed."

"Who else?"

"Voss and Vale."

A beat.

"You expecting a war?"

"No."

"Then you are overpaying."

"Arrive at eight."

Reyes disconnected without confirming.

Mac knew he would come.

Reyes considered refusing a large fee an admission that the danger

attached to it might be real.

Vale allowed the phone to ring until the last second.

“Mac.”

“I have work.”

“You usually have Voss call.”

“I need all three of you briefed together.”

“That is not what I said.”

Mac looked at the tracker.

The dot had stopped.

Not at a building. Not at a service station. On an unlit road between two small settlements.

He enlarged the map.

“Eight o’clock,” he said.

“What are you not telling Voss?”

“Nothing relevant.”

Vale remained silent.

She had an ability Mac disliked: not detecting lies exactly, but detecting the shape of the space built around them.

“Send the address,” she said.

“You know the address.”

“I wanted to hear whether you thought I did.”

She ended the call.

The tracker began moving again.

At seven fifty-two, Mac instructed the cleaner to leave the upper floor unfinished.

At seven fifty-six, he removed the visitor chairs and brought in a third.

At seven fifty-nine, Voss arrived.

He was in his late fifties, broad without heaviness, with iron-grey hair cut close and a face composed of patient lines. He carried no visible bag.

He entered, noted the window, the second door behind Mac's desk and the small camera above the corridor, then sat where he could see both exits.

His phone went face down on his thigh.

"You have seven minutes before Reyes arrives," Mac said.

"Six."

Reyes entered twenty seconds later.

He was younger than Voss by more than a decade and carried his size as though every room had been constructed slightly too small for him.

He had a paper cup in one hand and a packet of mints in the other.

Without looking, he tossed the mints to Voss.

Voss caught them.

"You still buying the wrong ones?" he asked.

"You still eating them."

Voss placed the packet beside his phone.

Reyes went to the window and checked his reflection rather than the view.

"Vale?"

"Coming," Voss said.

"You say that every time."

"She is always coming. She is never late."

The office door opened.

Vale stepped inside at eight exactly.

She wore a dark coat and carried a slim document case. Her hair was tied back.

Her gaze travelled across the room.

Three chairs.

Tracker displayed.

No refreshments.

Mac's private phone on the desk instead of in the drawer.

She took the remaining chair and moved it six inches to the left.

Reyes looked at her.

"What?"

"Your reflection was blocking the car park."

Reyes stepped away from the window.

Voss glanced at him, then at Vale, but said nothing.

Mac had used the three of them often enough to recognise the pattern.

Voss slowed down under pressure.

Reyes became louder.

Vale spoke less.

At that moment, Vale had said almost nothing.

Mac distributed three identical folders.

The front page described the assignment as the recovery of a protected minor from an unauthorised custodian.

Beneath it sat copies of travel permissions, placement records, photographs of Zoe and Elias, the hatchback's registration and a summary of the planned route.

The documents were technically sufficient to survive a casual roadside

question.

They were not designed to survive court.

Voss read every page.

Reyes looked first at the photographs.

Vale read the language around the signatures.

"Who is the authorised guardian?" she asked.

"The family representative named in the schedule."

"That is a company."

"The company holds delegated authority."

"From whom?"

"The placement provider."

"Which is another company."

Mac met her eyes.

"You are being contracted to recover the girl, not audit the structure."

Vale turned the page.

"Structures are usually where the bodies are."

Reyes placed Elias's photograph on the desk.

"This him?"

"Yes."

"He looks tired."

"He is."

"Then this will be quick."

Voss continued reading.

"Current location?"

Mac rotated the tablet towards them.

The tracker dot sat on a rural road.

"The vehicle carries a concealed transmitter," he said. "Live access will be supplied to Voss. It was installed before the airport collection."

"Detected?" Voss asked.

"No."

"Yet."

Mac did not answer.

Vale's gaze dropped briefly to Mac's hand.

His thumb rested against the edge of the desk.

She looked at Elias's photograph again.

"Why did he divert?"

"I do not know."

"You spoke to him?"

"He refused the calls."

"Before or after he passed the authorised destination?"

"After."

"So the decision came before the confrontation."

"Yes."

"What did the girl say?"

"I have not spoken to her."

Vale's eyes moved to the backpack visible in Zoe's airport photograph.

"What is she carrying?"

"Personal effects."

Mac answered too quickly.

Voss looked up from the page.

Reyes did not. He was still studying Elias's face.

"Have we worked this man before?" he asked.

"No."

"Military?"

"No record."

"Police?"

"No record."

"Prison?"

"No record."

"So he is a driver."

"For the purposes of this contract, he is a driver who has made an unauthorised decision under pressure."

Vale closed her folder.

"Not something else wearing a driver's file?"

The room became silent.

Mac thought of Cain's voice.

One word.

A lieutenant going pale.

He kept his hands still.

Voss looked at them anyway.

"Irrational people usually call someone," Voss said. "Family. Police. A friend. They do not switch to paper routes and minor roads."

"He may not be alone."

"Then your brief is incomplete."

"The brief contains what you need to perform the recovery."

Voss held Mac's gaze.

Then he made a small mark beside the paragraph and continued reading.

The payment terms appeared on the final page.

Half on acceptance through three separate consultancy accounts.

Half on confirmed recovery.

Expenses reimbursed against coded receipts.

No digital report.

No photographs beyond proof of transfer.

No police contact unless Mac authorised it.

Voss read the conditions aloud.

"Girl alive. No visible injury. Driver recoverable if practical, otherwise neutralised. Property carried by either subject returned intact."

Vale looked up.

"Personal effects?"

Mac did not answer.

Reyes smiled.

"There it is."

"There is what?" Mac asked.

"The reason a driver costs this much."

Mac folded his hands.

"The girl may possess confidential material belonging to the placement provider."

"What kind of material?" Voss asked.

"I do not know."

Vale held Mac's gaze for a moment longer, then looked back at the folder.

Voss turned to the operational page.

"We use standard protocol. One-hour check-ins while mobile. Fifteen minutes once inside target radius. Vehicles remain location-visible to the team. Nobody breaches alone."

Reyes looked at him.

"That last one is new."

"That last one is because you exist."

Vale opened her document case and removed three small sealed envelopes.

Inside each was a blank operational phone and a numbered battery.

She placed one before Voss, one before Reyes and kept one.

"Same channel as last time," she said. "No personal devices once we leave."

Reyes tapped Elias's photograph with one finger.

"You really need all this for him?"

Voss looked at the tracker.

"I need all this for anyone Mac pays us this much not to understand."

Mac did not react.

They signed separately.

Voss first, after crossing out a clause that permitted unilateral reassignment.

Vale second, adding the time beside her name.

Reyes did not read his copy. He signed across the marked line and

pushed it back.

Mac collected the pages.

“Departure tonight. The tracker currently places them several hours north-west of the planned route. You will approach without alerting local police or Cain’s people.”

Vale looked up.

“Cain is involved.”

“He is aware of the girl.”

“That was not my question.”

“His involvement is not operationally relevant.”

“Then why mention his people?”

“Because they may attempt an independent recovery.”

Reyes laughed.

“So there is another team.”

“There may be.”

“Friendly?”

“No.”

“Good.”

Voss placed his folder inside his coat.

“How much head start?”

“Several hours since the deviation.”

“And last confirmed visual?”

“Earlier today.”

“By whom?”

“A third party.”

Vale's eyes narrowed.

"Did the third party engage?"

"No."

"Why not?"

Mac looked at Elias's photograph.

"He chose not to."

Reyes shook his head.

"Then he was not much of a third party."

Mac did not tell them that Cain's lieutenant had been afraid.

He did not tell them the man had recognised Elias.

He did not tell them about the word Cain refused to say.

The omission was not accidental.

Some risks changed the price of a contract.

Others changed whether competent people accepted it at all.

Voss stood.

"We take the live feed until it fails. When it fails, the last location becomes contaminated, not confirmed. We search the surrounding road system, not the dot."

Mac nodded.

"Recover the girl."

"That is the contract."

"And Elias?"

Reyes answered before Voss could.

"I'll ask him why he missed his exit."

Vale rose and buttoned her coat.

“No. You’ll wait until we understand why he chose to.”

Reyes smiled at her.

“You worry too much.”

“You survive because I do.”

Voss’s mouth moved by less than a smile.

They left separately.

Vale first.

Reyes second.

Voss remained long enough to receive tracker access and confirm that the feed displayed on his operational phone.

At the door, he stopped.

“One question.”

Mac waited.

“Did you select Elias because he was ordinary, or because you needed him to be?”

The vacuum cleaner stood abandoned in the corridor beneath the emergency light.

Mac looked past Voss towards it.

“Bring back the girl.”

Voss accepted the non-answer and left.

The building became silent.

Mac locked the office door and returned to the desk.

Three signed agreements lay before him.

Three competent people were now moving towards a man Mac had described as ordinary.

Admitting the alternative would require something more dangerous

than ignorance.

It would require admitting that he had suspected the truth and used Elias anyway.

Mac opened the tracker map.

The dot had slowed again.

The road narrowed into a pale line across a dark rural region with few cameras and fewer houses.

At its current speed, the hatchback would reach the uplands after midnight.

Mac enlarged the map until individual bends appeared.

There was no marked destination.

There did not need to be.

A last clean position could still become a search radius.

Hours away, Zoe slept in the passenger seat beneath Elias's old jacket, one hand resting on the open road atlas.

Elias drove with the headlights dipped through another sleeping village.

He had shut down the phone.

He had abandoned the programmed route.

He was driving towards a cottage he believed Mac did not know existed.

Beneath the hatchback's rear quarter, sealed behind road dirt and black plastic, a green light pulsed once every thirty seconds.

On Mac's desk, the dot moved deeper into the dark.

Signal strength fell from three bars to one.

The position updated again.

Then again, twenty seconds late.

Mac watched the screen.

The next update did not come.